

Lesson 2: The Church

Introduction

We Christians realize that the most important parts of our lives are those that make an impact for eternity. The study of God and His relationship to, purposes for, and work within the created universe truly matters.

Welcome to our Link Group, where we focus on biblical small groups grounded in the teachings of God's Word. Our goal is to establish believers on a solid biblical foundation and to develop disciples who make disciples.

I. The Meaning of the Church

The word Church comes from the Greek word Ecclesia, meaning "the called-out ones." Christians are called out from the world's system to belong to Christ.

1 Corinthians 1:2 - "Unto the church of God which is at Corinth... called to be saints."

The Church, which is the Body of Christ, consists of all regenerated believers redeemed by the blood of Christ and transformed by the Holy Spirit. Only a portion of the Church is presently on earth; Christ is its unseen Head in heaven.

II. Distinctions of the Church

Local Church - A congregation in a specific location.

Universal Church - All true believers everywhere.

Actual Church - Imperfect believers growing in Christ.

Ideal Church - Believers already perfected in heaven.

Visible Church - Those identified with local congregations.

Invisible Church - Those whose names are written in the Lamb's Book of Life.

III. Who Founded the Church?

Jesus Christ established the Church upon Peter's confession that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of the living God (Matthew 16:16-18). Christ is both the Founder and the Head of the Church.

IV. How Does a Person Become Part of the Church?

A. Repentance (Acts 2:38)

B. Faith in the Lord Jesus Christ (Matthew 16:16-18)

C. Salvation, Regeneration, and the New Birth (Acts 2:47)

D. Baptism (Acts 2:38; Matthew 28:19; Acts 10:47-48; Acts 22:16)

E. Continuing in the Apostles' Doctrine (Acts 2:42)

V. The Purpose of the Church

- To worship and glorify God (Ephesians 1:4-6)
- To evangelize the world (Matthew 28:19-20; Mark 16:15)
- To teach and build believers (Ephesians 4:11-15)
- To be Christ's witnesses (Acts 1:8)

VI. The Ordinances of the Church

Baptism – Matthew 28:19–20; Mark 16:16; Acts 2:38–41; Acts 8:36–40; Acts 10:47–48.

The Lord's Supper – Acts 2:42–46; Acts 20:7; 1 Corinthians 11:20–34.

Conclusion

The church is not merely a building, organization, or denomination. According to Scripture, the Church is the Body of Christ, composed of all who have placed their faith in Jesus Christ for salvation. As members of His Church, we are called to worship God, proclaim the Gospel, grow in His Word, and faithfully represent Christ in the world.

Link Questions

1. What are some misconceptions you have had about the church?
2. Are you truly part of the Church through faith in Christ, or are you simply attending church services?
3. In what ways can you actively fulfill the mission of the Church this week?